

## VELIKYE LUKI DESIGNER'S NOTES

*Velikye Luki* is based on the well-received *Turning the Tables* (published by MiH in 1998) and *Drive to the Baltic!* (published by MiH in 1999) games. Originally, *Turning the Tables* and *Drive to the Baltic!* were intended as stand-alone games. The feedback on these games was very positive, and we noticed a strong demand from players for fast playing, easy-to-learn, non-simplistic games with an easily assimilated number of components. That was the reason to start a series using this game system.

*Velikye Luki* includes version 2.0 of the *TtT* system, newly dubbed the “T3” Operational Warfare System.. Some modifications were made in order to cover additional aspects of typical Eastern Front battles and to deal with different scales. In addition, the whole game system was streamlined and revised, and player's suggestions and ideas have been incorporated. Before discussing the changes and modifications, let me please first highlight the basic conceptual decisions made during the design stage of this series. This may be of interest for players unfamiliar with *Turning the Tables* and *Drive to the Baltic!*.

### Basic Concepts

The system is based on the idea of “Mechanical Simplicity”. Mechanical Simplicity means structuring the many complex elements in a game so that the player is not overburdened with memorization or bookkeeping. Mechanical Simplicity does not mean simplicity, it means a clear definition and contrast of themes. As a result, the game mechanics are realistic in effect and smooth in execution.

In order to make a game really playable, I find it imperative to concentrate on the most important factors of the subject chosen. Therefore, I incorporated many aspects directly into the basic game system rather than portraying them as independent functions under the player's direct control.

*Sequence of Play*-A traditional “Igo-Hugo” sequence of play was out of the question because such a mechanic would be too limited to capture the decisive aspects of warfare on the East Front during World War II. By breaking a game turn into three segments per side, the sequence of play allows some kind of inter-activity without burdening players with the amount of work and bookkeeping of an elaborate interactive game system.

The other important point of the sequence of play is allowing each player to decide what to carry out first in each of his segments-Fight or Move. This easy mechanic gives the player more control over his actions, thereby reflecting the decisions of real-world HQs (“Assault followed by Breakthrough” or “Maneuver before Combat”) in a smooth way.

*C3I Points*-This rather abstract term reflects each side's abilities to control and run operations (command control efficiency) as well as available resources (fuel, ammunition, general supplies). Similar to the decision what to carry out first in each of his segments (Fight or Move?), C3I Points give the player some control but face him with the dilemma of uncertainty. C3I Points work hand in hand with the sequence of play, preventing completely synchronized actions found in most games at this complexity level.

*Combat System*-The combat system integrates various important aspects of combat with a strong emphasis upon uncertainty and combined arms warfare. The combination of Tactical Superiority determination and Combat Chits made it possible to go with a rather elaborate combat system without increasing the complexity of the game or lengthening the rules. Players do not have to read several pages on air warfare, artillery effects, or doctrines in the rulebook. In addition, systems that are more-complex give players too much control on matters outside of their hands (like air support). Players will notice that the combat system captures the flair of World War II warfare on the Eastern Front and produces realistic results, but is still easy to handle and can be resolved quickly because it does not require a lot of calculations.

*Uncertainty*-Battles normally develop a dynamic course of their own which can never be fully controlled by the combatants. This aspect has been integrated into many game mechanics, like Activity Points determination, or Combat Chits. It avoids an unrealistic chess-like game play, and forces the player to fight his opponent rather than the game system.

### Modifications

My primary concern was to keep the game system as playable as possible. Version 2.0 of the *TtT* system includes four major modifications.

*Kessel subsystem*-This subsystem became necessary because pockets were a common feature of many East Front battles. Going hand in hand with the game system's basic idea (“Mechanical Simplicity”), aspects like supply dumps, isolation, attrition, air supply, or release are abstracted and directly incorporated into the Kessel Track.

*Activity Points*-The replacement of the former Movement and Combat Points gives players more control over their actions. The concept of Activity Points works hand in hand with the sequence of play.

*Limited Activity Segment*-This additional segment provides greater flexibility to the game system. Dealing with different scales would be out of the question without this segment.

*Combat System*-Following players' suggestions, Combat Chits have become more powerful. Players familiar with *Turning the Tables* or *Drive to the Baltic!* will notice the removal of “Dummy” Combat Chits. The introduction of Integrity intensifies the aspect of combined arms warfare and provides a strong tactical feel for combat resolution.

### Velikye Luki

The battle was small only by comparison to the truly massive battles at Stalingrad and the Rzhev salient, and did not receive much attention. However, the battle for Velikye Luki was important both in its own right and as a typical example of the fighting on the Eastern Front during the middle period. The battle saw a wide variety of colorful and interesting combat formations in action, and both sides conducted offensive operations as well as bitter last-ditch defenses. These aspects qualify Velikye Luki as an excellent subject for a game.

*Administrative Movement*-Different scales required a change of the Strategic Movement mechanic of *Turning the Tables* and *Drive to the Baltic!*. This change is not written in stone—future games of the series may use the original Strategic Movement mechanic.

*Order of Battle*-A lot of the research for this game is based on primary sources provided by native Russian and German speakers. **Velikye Luki** gives players the most accurate OOB ever done on this subject in game form and we are proud of it.

*Snafu Chit*-This Combat Chit is part of **Drive to the Baltic!** It adds uncertainty with a minimum of complexity to the game system. However, we noticed that the chit is not everyone's cup of tea, and removed it from the counter mix. Instead, the effects of Snafu are incorporated in the CRT; please take a look at the rows for a dice roll of 3 and 12.

*Combat Units*-Similar to my previous designs, the counters represent the fighting formations actually used rather than the administrative organizations. Speaking about the Red Army's rifle divisions, divisional assets like anti-tank, engineer, or artillery battalions differed tremendously from formation to formation and are incorporated in the strength of the rifle regiments. The German strongpoints represent the fortifications as well as the garrison troops. As pointed out in the Historical Commentary, most German infantry divisions had disbanded one of the battalions of their regiments and had created an independent battalion-sized *Kampfgruppe* as divisional reserve; these units were often called "Schnelles" (fast) battalion. The two German mobile divisions are represented by three strong *Kampfgruppen*, each consisting of motorized infantry and tank components formed around regimental and battalion-sized headquarters.

*7th Flieger-Division*-This elite division of paratroopers was located in a relatively quiet sector of the front about 20 miles southeast of the southern map edge. The entire division could have been committed to the battle—without doubt, the commitment would have had a major impact upon the course of the fighting. However, the formation was part of the *Luftwaffe*, and therefore under Goering's direct control. Goering was interested in maintaining it as a force in being, and released only a single battalion. I did not introduce *7th Flieger-Division* as an optional reinforcement because as with most "what if?" cases, the reactions of the other side (commitment of reserves?) would be purely speculative.

*Special features*-The rules for ski troops, strongpoints, infiltration movement, the "Brandenburger" commando unit, the release of the Velikye Luki garrison, and breakout units capture their historical importance and flair. In keeping an eye on the game's overall complexity and orientation, I reduced exceptions and special rules to a minimum.

## The Future

At the time of this writing, I have started work on the next installment of the series, **Backhand Blow**. **Backhand Blow** simulates the 3rd battle for the city of Kharkov in February and March 1943. It includes the Soviet operations *Star* and *Leap* as well as *von Manstein's Backhand Blow*. After Stalingrad, the Red Army attacked with the tasks of liberating the farmlands of the Ukraine and the important industrial Donets Basin as well as trapping two Axis armies against the Sea of Azov.

While each new installment will be a complete, stand-alone game, it will also be part of an overall series, with the express intent of telling the story of World War II on the Eastern Front. While the goal is not to strictly adhere to any chronological constraints, our aim is to take the story from the onset of *Unternehmen Barbarossa* to the Battle for Berlin with a total of 7 to 10 titles in all. Moreover, Western Front battles are a possibility, too. Players are cordially invited to join us and are urged to drop us a line with their feedback (using E-mail is most efficient), including suggestions for further topics for upcoming **T3** games..

Before closing, allow me to express my gratitude to all those who supported the series. Without their considerable efforts, finishing **Velikye Luki** would not have been possible. Enjoy the game!

Dirk Blennemann, March 2000